Stress and Health

What stress is, where it comes from, what it does to the body over months, how people cope — and which levers a manager actually controls to prevent burnout.

Isagi · November 2026 · Spine: Ciccarelli & White, *Psychology* (4th ed.), Ch. 11 — rewritten, updated and applied

Part 1 described the fight-or-flight response: heart racing, cortisol rising, the body ready for a short physical emergency. Sales work triggers that response often and rarely ends it — a monthly target, a dealer threatening to switch, a review on Monday. This part is about what happens when the emergency system stays on, why some people handle the same pressure better than others, and what the research says a manager can change. Most of the strongest levers turn out to be in the design of the job, not in individual resilience training.

1 What stress is

Stress is the physical, emotional and behavioural response to events we see as threatening or challenging. The events themselves are **stressors**. Not all stress is harmful: **eustress** is the positive, energising kind that comes with a challenge you expect to meet; **distress** is the kind that wears you down. The same event — a big new account — can be either, depending on how it's appraised (section 4).

2 Where stress comes from

- **Catastrophes** — floods, earthquakes, pandemics. Unpredictable, large-scale, often shared.
- **Major life changes** — even positive ones. In 1967 Thomas Holmes and Richard Rahe built the **Social Readjustment Rating Scale (SRRS)**, which scores 43 life events by how much adjustment they require: death of a spouse scores 100, divorce 73, marriage 50, being

fired 47. People with high totals over a year showed somewhat higher rates of illness.

- **Daily hassles** — traffic, a broken printer, a dealer who won't pick up. Individually trivial, they add up, and in several studies predict health and mood better than major life events.
- **Pressure**, **frustration** (being blocked from a goal) and **conflict** between options. In an **approach–avoidance** conflict, one option has both pulls and pushes — a promotion that comes with a transfer away from family — and people tend to waver as the decision nears.

WORKED EXAMPLE 1 · THE "GOOD NEWS" STRESS SCORE

An ASM is promoted to RSM and moves from Kochi to Pune. Score the year using SRRS values:

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Change in responsibilities at work   29
Outstanding personal achievement     28
Change in residence                  20
Change in living conditions          25
Change in work hours or conditions   20
Change in social activities          18
Spouse begins or stops work          26
                              Total 166
```

Every item is part of "good news", yet the total is substantial — about a third of the way to the 300 that Holmes and Rahe treated as high risk. The SRRS is a blunt tool, made in the 1960s for American adults, and it ignores how each person appraises events. But the point stands: transfers and promotions are stressful, and support during the first months — housing help, a buddy in the new region, a lighter first-quarter target — is not indulgence.

Stress built into jobs

Two well-tested models explain why some jobs are more stressful than others with the same workload:

- **Demand–control model** (Robert Karasek, 1979): the most damaging jobs combine **high demands** with **low control** over how and when

work is done. High demands with high control are "active" jobs — challenging but healthier.

- **Effort–reward imbalance** (Johannes Siegrist): stress rises when high effort meets low reward, where reward includes pay, but also recognition, job security and career prospects.

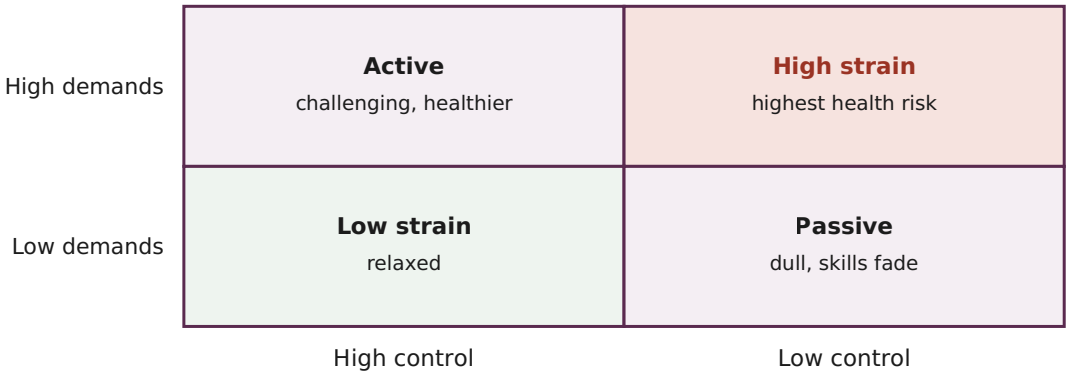


Figure 1. Karasek's demand–control model. Adding control to a demanding job moves it from "high strain" to "active" without lowering the target.

3 What stress does to the body

In the 1930s–50s Hans Selye described the **general adaptation syndrome (GAS)**, the body's response to any prolonged stressor, in three stages:

1. **Alarm** — the sympathetic nervous system fires; adrenaline surges; resistance briefly drops, then rises.
2. **Resistance** — the body sustains a high level of arousal to cope, using up resources.
3. **Exhaustion** — if the stressor continues, resources run down; vulnerability to illness rises.

Two systems carry the response. The fast **sympathetic–adrenal** route releases adrenaline in seconds. The slower **HPA axis** — hypothalamus to pituitary to adrenal glands — releases **cortisol**, which raises blood sugar and suppresses non-urgent functions, including parts of the immune system. Useful for an afternoon; harmful for a year.

The effects are measurable. In studies by Janice Kiecolt-Glaser and colleagues, medical students' immune markers dropped during exam periods, and a small standardised wound healed about 24% more slowly (about nine days longer) in people caring for a relative with dementia than in matched controls. Long-term stress is also linked with high blood pressure and heart disease, partly directly and partly through what stressed people do — sleep less, eat worse, smoke and drink more, exercise less.

A famous correction: for decades stomach ulcers were blamed mainly on stress. In the 1980s Barry Marshall and Robin Warren showed most are caused by a bacterium, *Helicobacter pylori*, and treatable with antibiotics; they won the 2005 Nobel Prize. Stress may still worsen ulcers, but it isn't the main cause — a reminder that "it's just stress" can hide a treatable condition.

4 It depends how you see it

Richard Lazarus's **cognitive appraisal** model says stress depends on two judgements. **Primary appraisal**: is this event irrelevant, a **threat** (possible harm) or a **challenge** (possible gain)? **Secondary appraisal**: do I have the resources to cope? A demanding new target appraised as a challenge you can meet produces energy; appraised as a threat you can't handle, it produces distress. Research on work stressors supports the distinction: "challenge" demands such as responsibility and time pressure tend to go with higher motivation, while "hindrance" demands such as red tape, role confusion and office politics go with lower performance and more strain.

This gives managers a cheap lever: secondary appraisal depends on perceived resources. Telling a rep what support exists — budget for a scheme, help from the key-account team, your time — changes how the same target lands.

5 Personality and stress

- **Type A** — the competitive, impatient, hostile pattern described by cardiologists Meyer Friedman and Ray Rosenman in the 1950s, and

linked to heart disease. Later research found the overall Type A pattern was a weak predictor; the toxic ingredient is **hostility** — cynical mistrust and anger. Ambition and drive alone are not the problem.

- **Hardiness** (Suzanne Kobasa) — a combination of **commitment** (involvement in what you do), **control** (believing you can influence events) and **challenge** (seeing change as opportunity). Associated with better health under stress.
- **Optimism** — expecting good outcomes — is linked with better coping and health, partly because optimists take more active steps.

6 Social and cultural factors

Social support — people you can turn to for help, advice or company — is one of the strongest buffers against stress, and isolation is a health risk comparable to well-known physical ones in some large studies. Field sales is structurally isolating: reps spend most days alone on the road. Regular team contact, buddies in new regions and a manager who calls to ask how things are going, not only about numbers, are part of the job design. Moving between cultures brings **acculturative stress** — relevant to transfers between regions with different languages and food. Poverty and job insecurity are chronic stressors in their own right.

7 Coping

Problem-focused coping deals with the stressor itself: planning, asking for help, negotiating a target. **Emotion-focused coping** manages the feelings: exercise, talking it through, reframing, relaxation. Problem-focused coping works best when the situation can be changed; emotion-focused coping helps when it can't. Avoidance — denial, drinking, withdrawing — gives short relief and long costs.

Among specific methods, regular **physical exercise** has some of the most consistent evidence for reducing stress and improving mood. **Mindfulness meditation** has moderate evidence: a 2014 review of trials found moderate improvements in anxiety, depression and pain, with

smaller or unclear effects on other outcomes. It helps; it isn't a cure-all, and an app subscription isn't a substitute for fixing an impossible workload.

8 Burnout

Christina Maslach defined **burnout** by three features: **exhaustion**, **cynicism** (detachment from the work and the people it serves) and **reduced efficacy** (feeling ineffective). Since 2019 the World Health Organization's ICD-11 has listed burnout as an **occupational phenomenon** resulting from chronic workplace stress that has not been successfully managed — not as a medical condition. The definition places the cause in the job.

Maslach and Michael Leiter identified six areas where mismatches between person and job drive burnout. They double as a manager's checklist:

Area	Mismatch	Lever
Workload	Too much, with no recovery	Realistic targets; protect days off
Control	No say in how work is done	Let reps plan beats and schemes within limits
Reward	Effort unrecognised	Timely pay-outs; specific recognition
Community	Isolation or conflict	Regular team contact; deal with toxic behaviour
Fairness	Favouritism, opaque decisions	Transparent target and territory allocation
Values	Asked to act against one's ethics	No pressure to mislead dealers or load stock

WORKED EXAMPLE 2 · MOVING A JOB OUT OF "HIGH STRAIN"

Score two rep roles on demands and control, 1 (low) to 5 (high), from a team survey (illustrative):

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                      Demands  Control   Quadrant
Urban rep (today)       5        2      High strain
Urban rep (redesign)    5        4      Active
Rural rep               3        4      Low strain
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The redesign kept the demands — same target — but raised control: reps choose their visit sequence, approve small schemes up to a limit, and set one day a week for admin. On the Karasek model that moves the role from the riskiest quadrant to the healthiest demanding one, without cutting the number.

9 Held up?

Claim	Verdict	Why
Chronic stress harms immunity and the heart	**Supported**	Consistent evidence from lab, field and long-term studies.
Type A personality causes heart disease	**Partly**	The broad pattern is a weak predictor; hostility is the active ingredient.
Ulcers are caused by stress	**Mostly no**	Mostly bacterial; stress may aggravate them.
Mindfulness reduces stress	**Moderately**	Moderate effects on anxiety and depression in trials; not a fix for job design.
High demands plus low control is especially harmful	**Supported**	Repeated in large studies of workers, though effect sizes vary.
Burnout is a personal weakness	**No**	WHO defines it as a result of unmanaged workplace stress.

Summary

- **Stress** is the response to events appraised as threatening or challenging; **eustress** energises, **distress** wears down.
- Stressors include catastrophes, life changes (scored by the **SRRS**; even promotions and transfers score highly), daily hassles, frustration and conflict.
- Jobs combining **high demands with low control**, or high effort with low reward, are the most stressful.
- Selye's **GAS**: alarm, resistance, exhaustion. Cortisol from the HPA axis suppresses immunity; chronic stress slows healing and is linked to heart disease.
- **Appraisal** decides whether a demand feels like a threat or a challenge; perceived resources matter.
- **Hostility**, not ambition, is the harmful part of Type A. Hardiness and optimism help.
- **Social support** is a powerful buffer; field sales is isolating by design.
- **Coping**: problem-focused when the situation can change, emotion-focused when it can't. Exercise has strong evidence, mindfulness moderate.
- **Burnout** — exhaustion, cynicism, reduced efficacy — is an occupational phenomenon. Its six drivers (workload, control, reward, community, fairness, values) are mostly in the manager's hands.

Practice problems

P1. A rep gets married (50), takes a home loan for a major purchase (31), moves house (20) and changes work hours after a territory change (20). What is his SRRS total? What would you do as his manager?

P2. Classify each as a challenge or hindrance stressor: (a) handling a large new key account; (b) three different managers giving conflicting instructions; (c) a tight launch deadline; (d) waiting two weeks for scheme approvals.

P3. Place these roles on Karasek's model and suggest one change for the worst: (a) a call-centre agent with scripted calls and timed breaks; (b) a regional head with high targets and full budget authority.

P4. A rep has become cynical about dealers, feels drained and says nothing he does makes a difference. Which concept fits? Name three of the six areas you would check first.

P5. HR proposes a mindfulness app for everyone as the response to rising attrition in field sales. Evaluate the proposal.

P6. Using secondary appraisal, rewrite this message to make the same target feel more manageable: "Your Q3 target is ₹1.2 crore. Make it happen."

Glossary

Stressor

An event that triggers a stress response.

Eustress / distress

Positive, energising stress / harmful stress.

SRRS

A scale scoring life events by the adjustment they require.

Daily hassles

Small, everyday irritations that add up.

Approach–avoidance conflict

One option with both attractive and unattractive features.

Demand–control model

Strain is highest when demands are high and control is low.

General adaptation syndrome

Selye's alarm, resistance and exhaustion stages.

HPA axis

Hypothalamus–pituitary–adrenal pathway that releases cortisol.

Primary / secondary appraisal

Judging whether an event is a threat or challenge / whether you can cope.

Challenge / hindrance stressor

A demand that offers growth / one that just obstructs.

Hardiness

Commitment, control and challenge as a stress-resistant outlook.

Social support

Help, advice and company from others.

Problem- / emotion-focused coping

Changing the situation / managing the feelings.

Burnout

Exhaustion, cynicism and reduced efficacy from unmanaged work stress.

Answer key

P1. 50 + 31 + 20 + 20 = **121**. Check in, avoid loading extra change onto him this quarter (no new territory, no extra projects), and offer flexibility around the wedding and move.

P2. (a) challenge; (b) hindrance (role conflict); (c) challenge; (d) hindrance (red tape).

P3. (a) high demands, low control: high strain. Give agents more say — flexible break timing, discretion to resolve issues without escalating. (b) high demands, high control: active.

P4. Burnout. Start with workload, control and reward; also check fairness of target allocation.

P5. Mindfulness has moderate benefits for individuals, but burnout is driven by job conditions. Offer it as one support, alongside fixing workload, control, reward and fairness, and measure whether attrition actually changes.

P6. For example: "Your Q3 target is ₹1.2 crore. You'll have the Diwali scheme budget, the key-account team's support on the two large builders, and a weekly call with me to unblock anything."

Sources: chapter structure follows Ciccarelli & White, *Psychology*, 4th ed. (Pearson), Ch. 11; text and figures are original. Holmes & Rahe, 1967. Karasek, *Administrative Science Quarterly*, 1979. Siegrist, 1996. Kiecolt-Glaser et al., *The Lancet*, 1995. Challenge and hindrance stressors: LePine, Podsakoff & LePine, *Academy of Management Journal*, 2005. Mindfulness: Goyal et al., *JAMA Internal Medicine*, 2014. Burnout: Maslach & Leiter; WHO ICD-11, 2019. Survey scores in worked example 2 are illustrative.